tolerance. Finally, the Revolutionary Council proclaimed freedom of the press.

Several weeks after the coup, the Revolutionary Council announced the government plan that was to be known as the “Burmese Way to Socialism.” The focus of the document was both social and economic. Popular participation would be encouraged and a high priority was placed on guaranteeing the basic necessities, such as food, security, shelter, and clothing. The rhetoric of the document was egalitarian with an emphasis on narrowing the income gap and promoting unity.

In order to foster national cohesiveness, the Revolutionary Council decided that a single-party state would be established. The legacy of the Anti-Fascist People's Freedom League (AFPFL) infighting of the late 1950s played into this decision. After the main parties failed to merge, the Burmese Socialist Party (BSP) was established. Representatives from the Pyidaungsu Party, the AFPFL, and the National United Front were told that assets would be seized, including the forfeiting of all property. Continuation of political activity not associated with the BSP would lead to jail time. The goal of the party was nation building and the ideology borrowed from Marxism as the guiding principle was to be “democratic centralism.”

One of the early targets of the Revolutionary Council was civil liberty. The government at first claimed that civil liberties would be preserved as long as they did not threaten the security of the state. An especially problematic area was press freedom. The regime felt that a supportive media was essential to build nationalism and loyalty to the state. The media could help slow down the moral decay of the colonial and early postcolonial years. Within the first two years of the new regime, horse racing was banned, and dance halls and ballet schools were closed.

The xenophobic nature of the regime was exemplified with the treatment of the press. Foreign coverage was to be tightly controlled. The New Agency Burma was established to control international media coverage. This was a step toward eliminating an independent media. Additionally, the government could control press credentials to ensure that only pro-government journalists were in the field. The mindset of the regime was that the press was there to serve the population and promote patriotism. Furthermore, the press should be cautious and avoid sensationalism and any